

Civilisation, as a foundationalist ontology¹, is fashioned by ideas, before it is constructed as social phenomena by institutions.

1. Positivists believe that a social reality exists and that reality is knowable and you can study it. (Porta and Keating, 2012; 23) Positivists emphasise the “science” in social science, far more than the social constructivists who believe that reality is constructed. Positivists say that if gravity or natural selection can be considered a truth, then surely it is possible to be as certain about things that are socially constructed. Positivism however, is not a theory; it is an approach informs a researcher how to approach a chosen subject or topic. This short critical review will look at some of the main points and debates within positivism, explaining what it is and how it influences our study of the world.

Positivism has been the dominant mode of study in international relations in the last forty years. (Smith, 1996; 11) The importance of studying epistemological approaches is the theory of the approach ‘underpins and informs international practice...Once established as common sense theories become incredibly powerful since they delineate not simply what can be known but also what it is sensible to talk about.’ (Smith, 1996;13) Different approaches of study can result in different results and trying to gain an empirical view of the world.

The positivist position is firmly based upon a foundationalist ontology. (Furlong and Marsh, 2010; 193) The world according to the positivist exists independently from our view of it. It is from this position that positivists try and gain knowledge about the world.

The difficulty for positivists is that empiricism is a lot harder to prove in the natural sciences. That Boris Johnson is prime minister is a fact (at the time of writing), and you would struggle to find anybody who would dispute this. Yet despite some truths being self-evident, the studying who is the prime minister does not occupy the minds of scholars. The world is far more complex and has more moving parts

What is the methodology used by positivists? Furlong and Marsh say that to the positivist, the natural sciences and social sciences are ‘broadly analogous,’ (Furlong and Marsh, 2010; 194) they say that positivists can use hypotheses which can be tested by direct observation. Furlong and Marsh continue to say that it is positivists aim to ‘establish causal relationships between social phenomena.’ Positivists continue to say that one can separate empiricism from normative questions, “questions about what is,” to questions about, “what should be.” (Furlong and Marsh, 2010; 194) Their ontological position is clear: they believe that social reality does exist.

Not only do positivists believed that the world quantifiable, but also that the world is fixed. (Parker, 2016; 44) This ontological position then informs their epistemology and their methodology of how they gain knowledge.

Positivist epistemology, Nicholson claims, makes ‘generalisations about the social world... which are verifiable.’ (Nicholson, 1996; 128) This is how positivists gain knowledge of the world via direct observations and trying to ‘predict the consequences of actions carried out now or in the

future.’ (Nicholson, 1996; 132) Positivists identify a theory, and this must be testable by observation, via deduction or direct observation. When one calls themselves a positivist, it is not a view of the world, but how to investigate the world.

Despite their reputation for being cold scientists, positivists are idealists, they try to fit the complex world into data sets for it to be analysed is not an easy task. Some things may be easier to quantify than others, ‘red-haired people usually have blue eyes.’ (Nicholson, 1996; 135) But trying to answer the question in a scientific manner of what caused the French Revolution or the vote for Britain to leave the European Union causes a mountain of problems. These are complex and difficult and have been debated for a long time, and will continue to be debated. If a political historian in the positivist tradition tried to study the French Revolution they would be struck with a lack of hard data from the time. In the case of Brexit, there is plenty of data, but untangling it proves extremely difficult. Nicholson raises several other problems with quantifying, if you ask ‘what is the population of London,’ and ‘how many languages are spoken in London,’ you are faced with the quantification problem of what are the boundaries of London, and what is a language?’ (Nicholson, 1996; 137) The arbitrariness of entities in the social world is far more complex than in the natural sciences.

There are two main criticisms of positivism (Furlong and Marsh, 2010); 195) First is the pragmatic position that Quine (1961) takes in his famous essay, ‘Two Dogmas of Empiricism.’ He claimed that there was no easy way to separate the analytic-synthetic distinction. Analytic distinctions that are true by their meaning and synthetic statements are those ‘deemed true by convention,’ (Smith, 1996; 20) and the second criticism as Smith writes is that, ‘even the most simple acts of “pure” observation involve a web of belief which is both far removed and far more complex than the individual act of observation.’

Furlong and March say that while Quine’s observations might be true, some positivist social sciences ‘minimize these difference’ while others accept this trade off as part of their research. This leads towards a middle ground that could be called an ‘interpretivist epistemological position.’

The obfuscation between certain positivist and interpretivist approaches highlighted by writers such as David Sanders points at a new era in the positivist tradition. Sanders argues that a new movement called the ‘post-positivist’ has emerged from those who still see themselves as largely positivists but accept the interdependence of theory and observation. (Sanders, 2010; 40) Sanders accepts that interpretation and meaning is important. He states that ‘there are other areas - relating to the way in which individuals reflect, to a great or lesser degree, upon themselves - here behavioural electoral research has simply not dared to treat.’ (Sanders, 2010; 31) Positivism has ‘change in response to criticism.’ (Furlong and Marsh, 2010; 198)

Smith states that he believes positivism ‘cannot be resurrected.’ (Smith, 1996;38) However Smith credit positivism with an important effect on the nature of the study of international relations.

The problem of how to gain empirical knowledge made its first steps with the positivist approach, but the search for a 'valid theory in the Popperian sense,' (Bernstein et al. 2000; 44) is still elusive. The political sciences have tried, but after 50 years of 'developing analytical tools' we are still nowhere nearer to gaining a grand theory on the scale of natural selection or Newtonian physics.

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